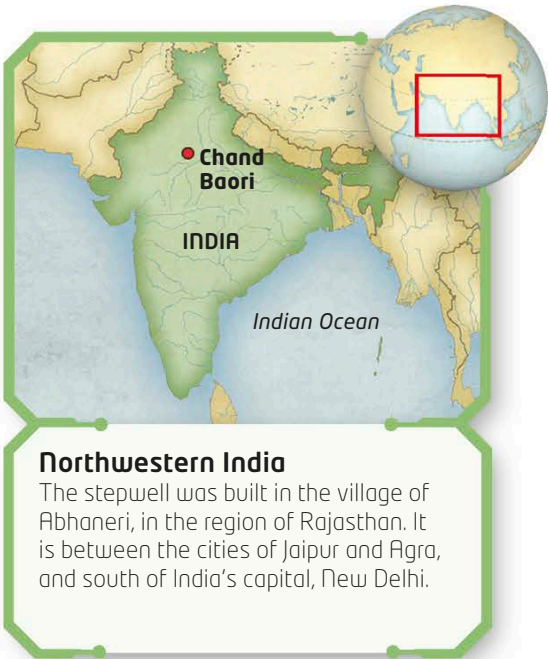
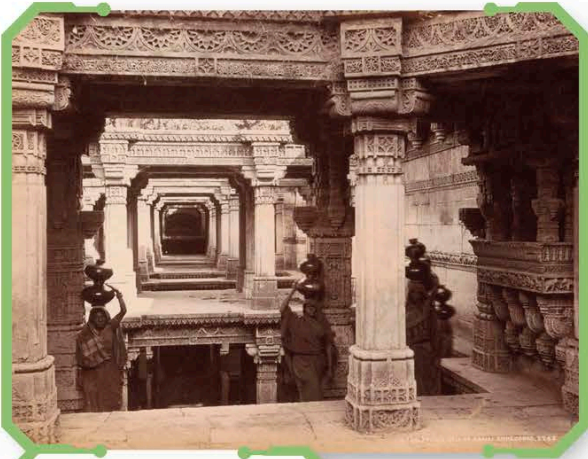


INDIAN STEPWELL

Stacks of symmetrical staircases plunge down toward cool water at the stepwell of Chand Baori. It was built in the 9th century by Raja Chanda, ruler of a small Rajput kingdom. Many such stepwells were built across India over more than a thousand years, often by queens for village women. They are beautiful feats of engineering as well as places to collect water.



Northwestern India
The stepwell was built in the village of Abhaneri, in the region of Rajasthan. It is between the cities of Jaipur and Agra, and south of India's capital, New Delhi.



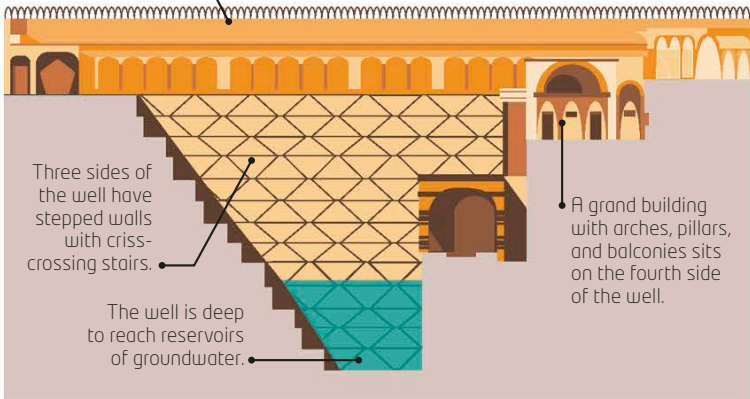
Wells through time
The most ornate stepwells were built in the dry areas of northwest India. As this photo shows, the carved well at Adalaj in Gujarat was still in use in the late 19th century. Once women had filled clay or brass pots at the well, they balanced stacks of them on their heads to climb the steps.



This carving from Chand Baori is of Durga, the Hindu warrior goddess and mother of the universe.

Water gods
Some stepwells are decorated with intricate carvings of gods, goddesses, and water spirits. As well as water sources, stepwells were places where people could pray, meditate, and leave offerings to the Hindu deities. Many stepwells are still used as places of worship today.

Today, a covered walkway with arches runs around the top of the well.



Stepwell design
India's stepwells were designed to help people reach water that lay hidden underground. Often built by wealthy women so village women could gather water, the stepwell's steep walls shaded the deep water, keeping the women cool.

